Nature Illustration Log — User Manual

Nov 10, 2026 · @Jim

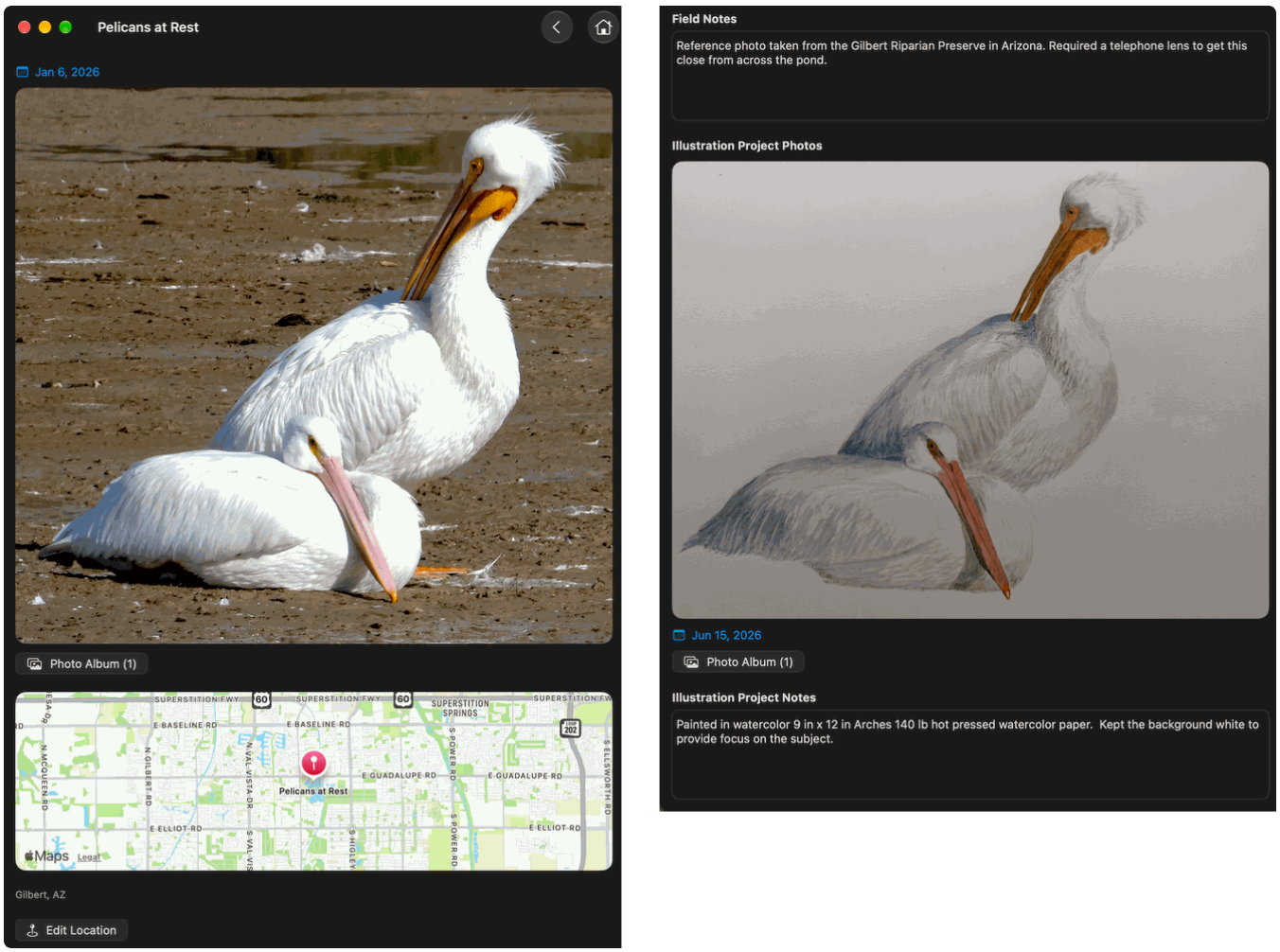
About this manual

Nature Illustration Log keeps your nature subjects in one place: photos of each subject, where you found it, your field notes, and project notes and photos for the illustration you make from it.

Each subject is a **file**. A file holds:

- **Subject photos**, each with the date it was taken
- **A map with pinned location** where you saw the subject
- **Field Notes** and **Illustration Project Notes**
- **Illustration Project Photos**: photos of your finished or in-progress illustration

The app runs on **iPhone, iPad and Mac**. Each device keeps its own files; you move files between them yourself (see *Moving files between your devices*). The app's buttons and messages appear in English. Your own names and notes are never translated.



Left: File Screen (top). Right: File Screen (bottom) (Mac)

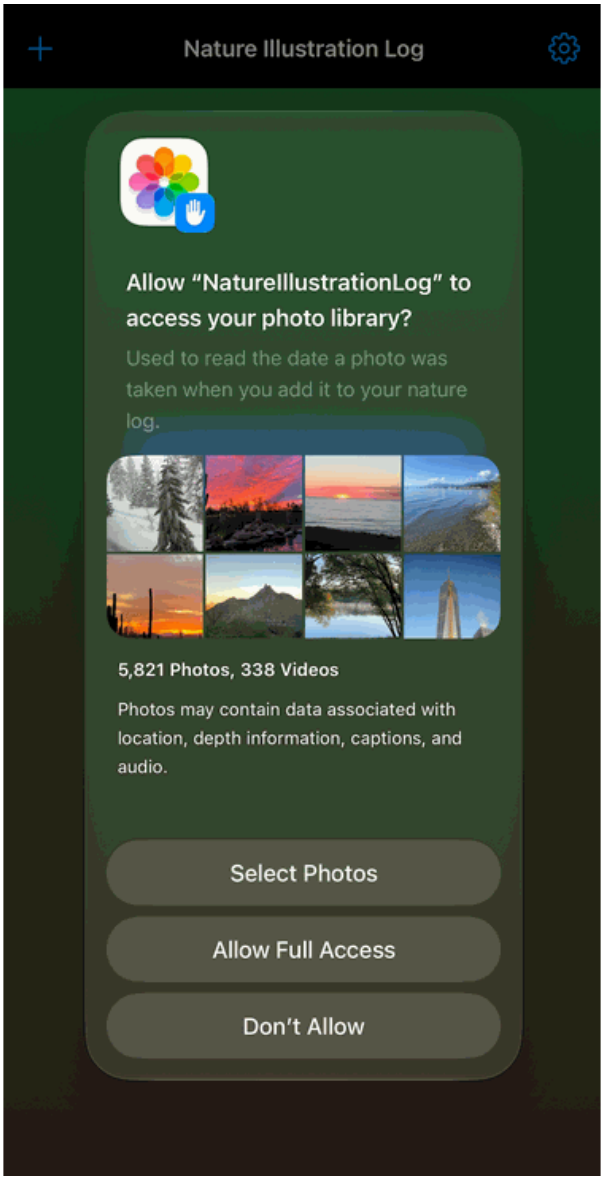
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1. Getting started

On first launch the app asks for **Photos access**. Choose **Allow Full Access** so photo dates fill in automatically. Without it you can still add photos, but you enter dates by hand. When you first open the map, the app asks for **Location access** so it can show where you are.

On iPhone and iPad, the first time you tap **Take Photo** the app asks for **Camera access**. After your first photo it also asks to **add photos** to your Photos library, where it saves the full-quality original.



Photos permission prompt (iPhone)

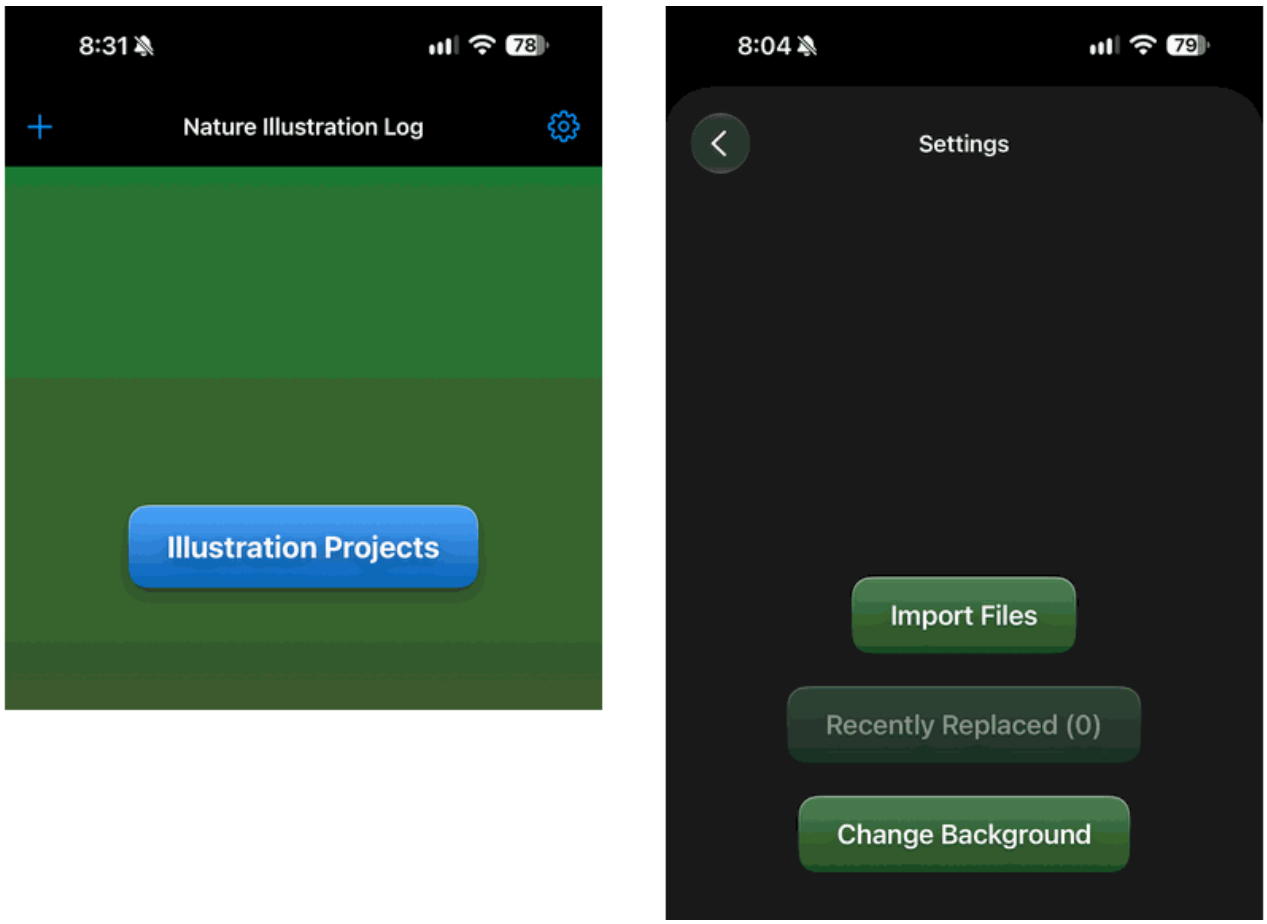
The Home screen

- **+** (top left): add a new file.

- **Gear** (top right): open **Settings**.
- **Illustration Projects** (center) button: open your list of files.
- On iPhone and iPad, the app's name appears in the top bar. On the Mac it appears in the window's title bar.

Settings

- **Import Files**: bring in files sent from another device (see *Moving files between your devices*).
- **Recently Replaced (n)**: older versions kept for 30 days after an Update. Dimmed when empty.
- **Change Background**: choose a photo for the Home screen. The previous background is removed.
- **Optimize Photo Storage**: shrinks photos added before this feature existed, to save space (see *Adding photos* in section 3). It asks first, shows progress, then tells you how much space was saved. This can't be undone on that device; the originals in your Photos library aren't affected.
- **Help** (top right of Settings): choose **Nature Illustration Log Help** to open the support web page, with answers to common questions, the support email address, and a link to this manual. On the Mac, the same item is also in the menu bar under Help (⌘?).



Left: Home screen with the default background. Right: Settings screen (iPhone)

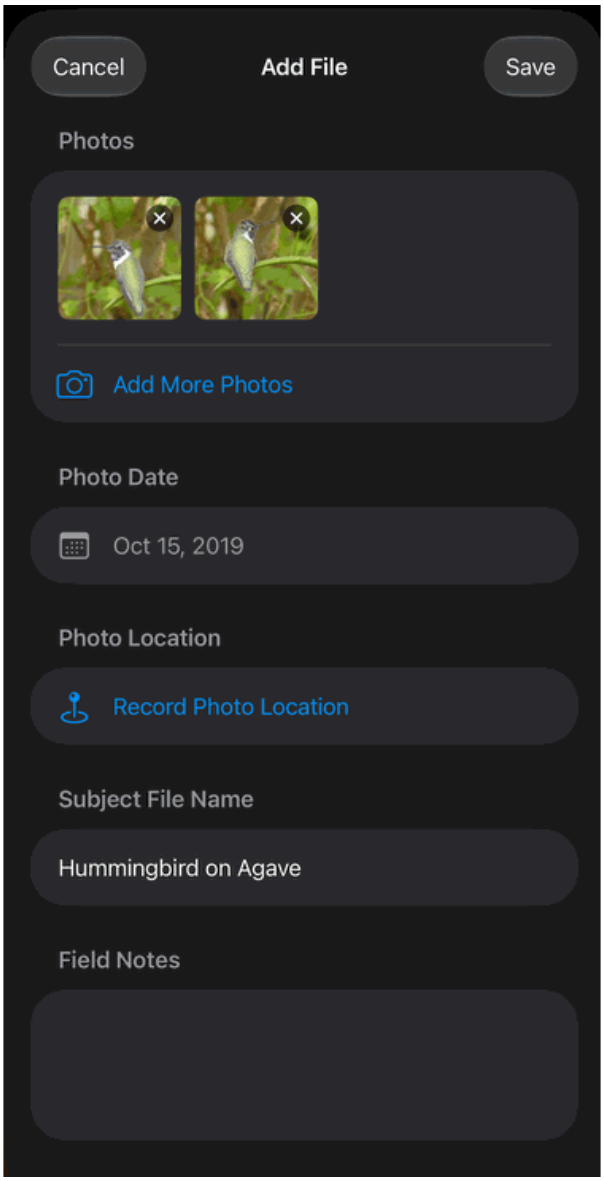
2. Files

A new file needs at least one photo and a unique name; everything else is optional and can be added later.

Adding a file

1. Tap **+** on the Home screen or the File List (Mac: **File → New File**, ⌘N).
2. Tap **Add Photos** and choose **Take Photo** (iPhone and iPad), **Photos Library** or **Files**. From Photos Library or Files you can pick several photos at once.
3. Check the **Photo Date**. Dates fill in from the photos when available. If any photo has no date, tap the red **Choose Date**, pick the date in the calendar and tap **Done**. **Save** stays dimmed until a date is chosen.
4. Optional: tap **Record Photo Location** to pin where you found the subject.
5. Enter a **Subject File Name**. Names must be unique; if the name exists you'll see **File Exists**.

6. Optional: type **Field Notes** and **Illustration Project Notes**.
7. Tap **Save**. **Cancel** discards everything.



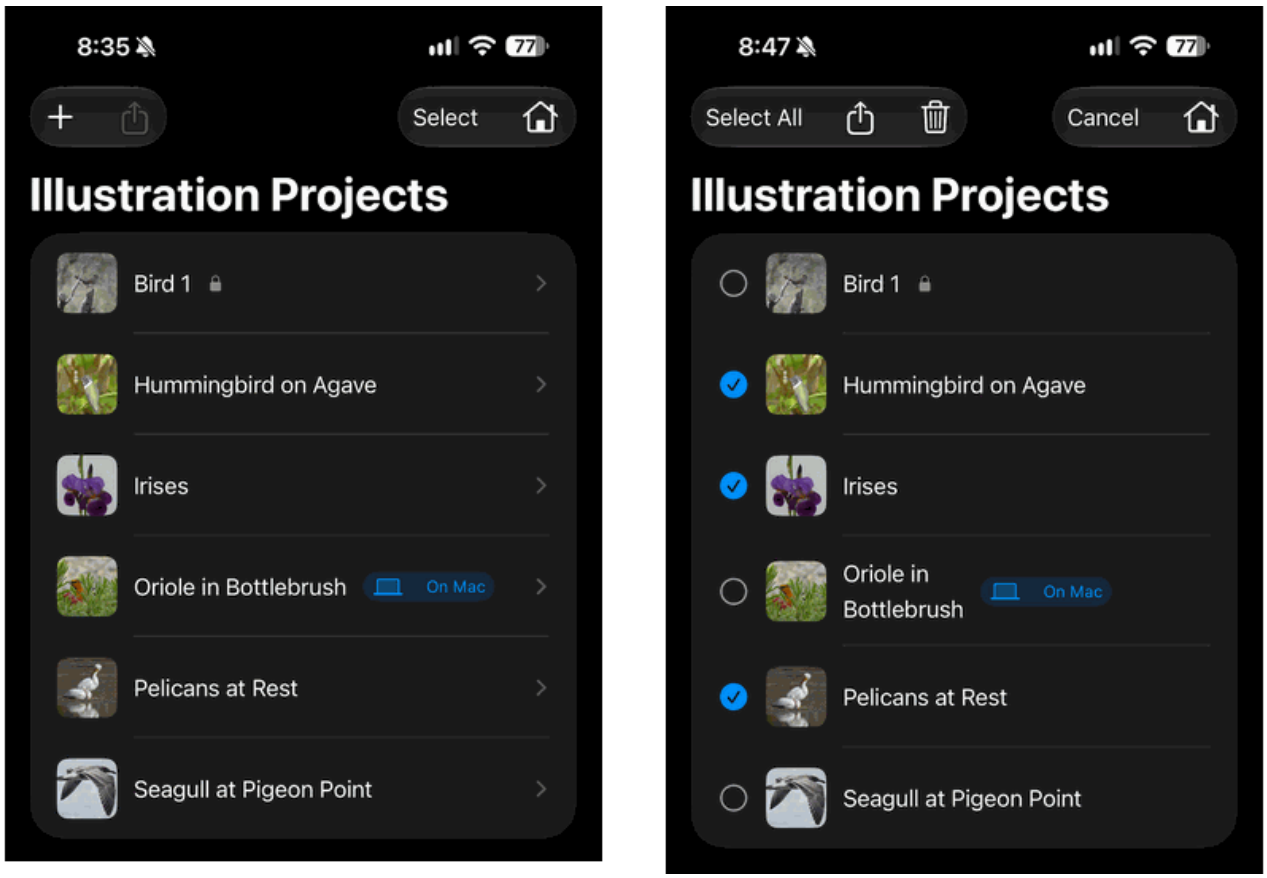
Add File screen with two photos and a name (iPhone)

The File List

Tap **Illustration Projects** on Home to see all files in alphabetical order. Tap a file to open its **File Screen**. Notes, dates and the location save automatically as you edit.

Symbols next to a name:

- **Lock**: a read-only copy someone shared with you.
- **On Mac**: a lightweight copy whose full photos are on your Mac.



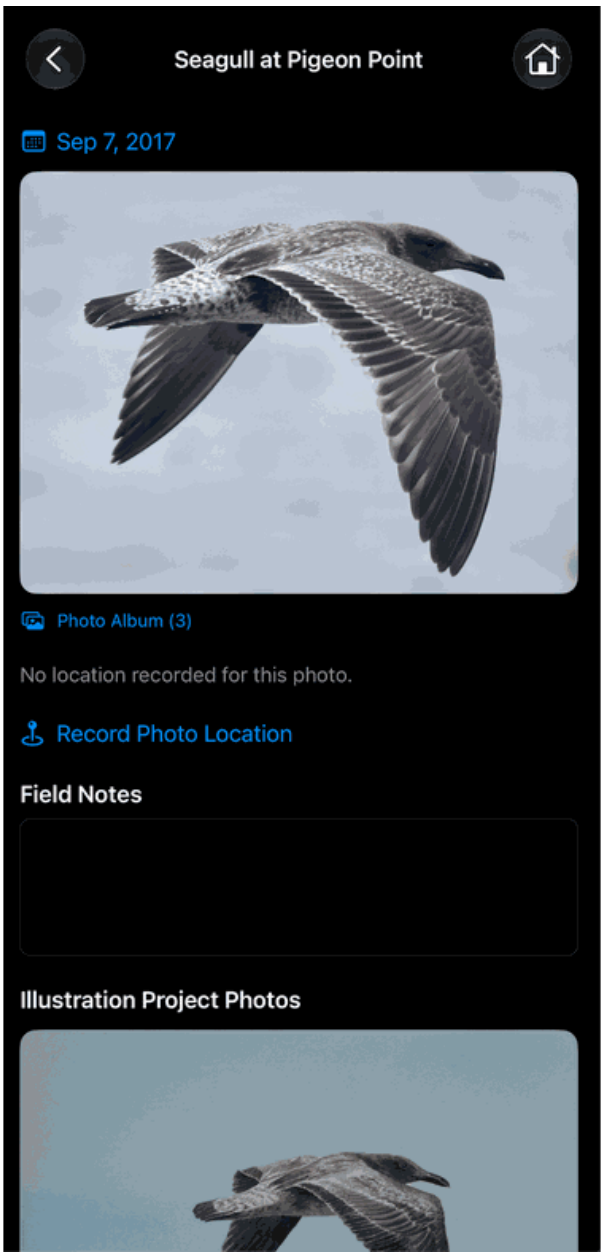
Left: File List with a locked file and an On Mac file. Right: Select mode with three files checked (iPhone)

Deleting files

- **One file:** swipe left on it and tap **Delete** (Mac: right-click → Delete).
- **Several files:** tap **Select**, tap the circle in front of each file you want (tap again to uncheck), then tap the **trash** icon (Mac: or press Delete). **Select All** checks every file.
- The app always asks first. Deleting can't be undone.

3. Photos and albums

Every file has two albums: **Photos** (the subject) and **Illustration Photos** (your artwork). The File Screen shows the first photo of each; the first subject photo is also the file's thumbnail in the File List.



File Screen with the subject photo and the start of Illustration Project Photos (iPhone)

Opening an album

Tap the photo or the **Photo Album (n)** link under it. Each row shows a thumbnail and the photo's date.

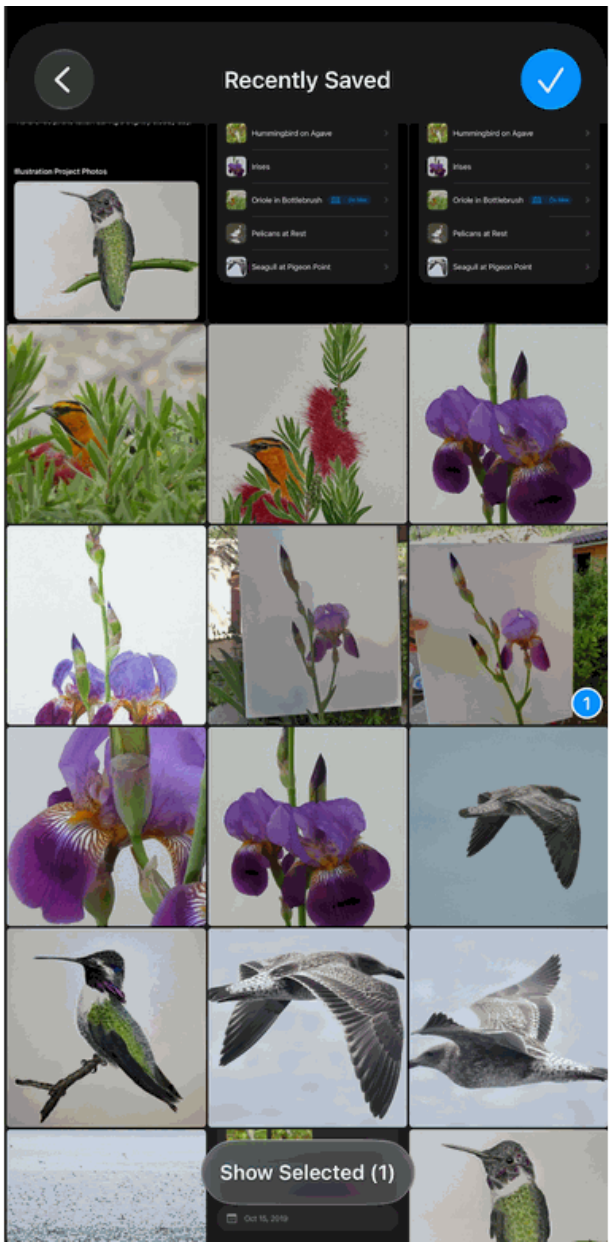
Adding photos

Tap **+** in the album (or **Add Photos** / **Add Illustration Photos** on the File Screen) and choose:

- **Take Photo** (iPhone and iPad only): opens the camera. Take the picture, then tap **Use Photo** (or **Retake**). The photo is dated the moment you took it, and the full-quality original is also saved to your Photos library. It takes one photo each time; tap **Take Photo** again for another.
- **Photos Library**: your Photos app. On the Mac, the Mac's Photos library (it includes iPhone photos if iCloud Photos is on).
- **Files**: image files from iCloud Drive, Downloads, On My iPhone, or any Mac folder. The date is read from the camera information inside the file when present. Camera RAW files are converted automatically.

Photos are copied into the app, so later changes in Photos or Finder don't affect them.

To save space, the app stores each photo at most 4096 pixels on its longest side, about 1.5–2 MB instead of the 8–10 MB of a full camera photo. That is still sharp when you zoom in. Photos added before this was introduced can be shrunk with **Settings → Optimize Photo Storage**.



Choosing a photo from the Photos Library (iPhone)

Photo dates

Tap a photo's date to open the date panel, pick a day and tap **Done**. A photo without a date shows a red **Set date**.

Organizing and deleting

- **Set as First:** swipe right on a photo (Mac: right-click). It becomes the photo shown on the File Screen.
- **Delete one:** swipe left (Mac: right-click → Delete).

- **Delete several:** tap **Select**, tap each photo's circle, then the **trash** icon.

Viewing full screen

Tap a thumbnail to see the photo full screen. Swipe left or right for the next photo. To zoom, pinch (trackpad or screen) or double-tap / double-click; drag to look around; double-tap again to return.



Full Photo View (iPhone)

4. Photo location

You place the location pin on a map, by hand or with the location arrow; the app does not read locations from photos, which are often missing or inaccurate.

1. Tap **Record Photo Location** (Add File or File Screen), or **Edit Location** to change an existing pin.
2. The map opens on your current location, or on the existing pin. On the Mac it fills the window; resize the window or use full screen for a larger map.
3. To jump elsewhere, type a place in **Search for a place** and press Return. The map moves there without dropping a pin.
4. Pinch to zoom and drag to move. Switch **Map** / **Satellite** at the bottom.
5. Tap the spot where you found the subject. Tap again to move the pin. If you're standing at the spot now, tap the **location arrow** in the map's lower-right corner instead: the map moves to where you are and drops the pin there. A spinner shows while it finds you (up to about 10 seconds).
6. Tap **Done** to save, or **Cancel** to leave without changes.

On the File Screen the map shows the pin and a short place name. Tap the map for **Full Map View**, a larger read-only map with Map / Satellite.

Searching and place names need an internet connection; you can still drop a pin offline.

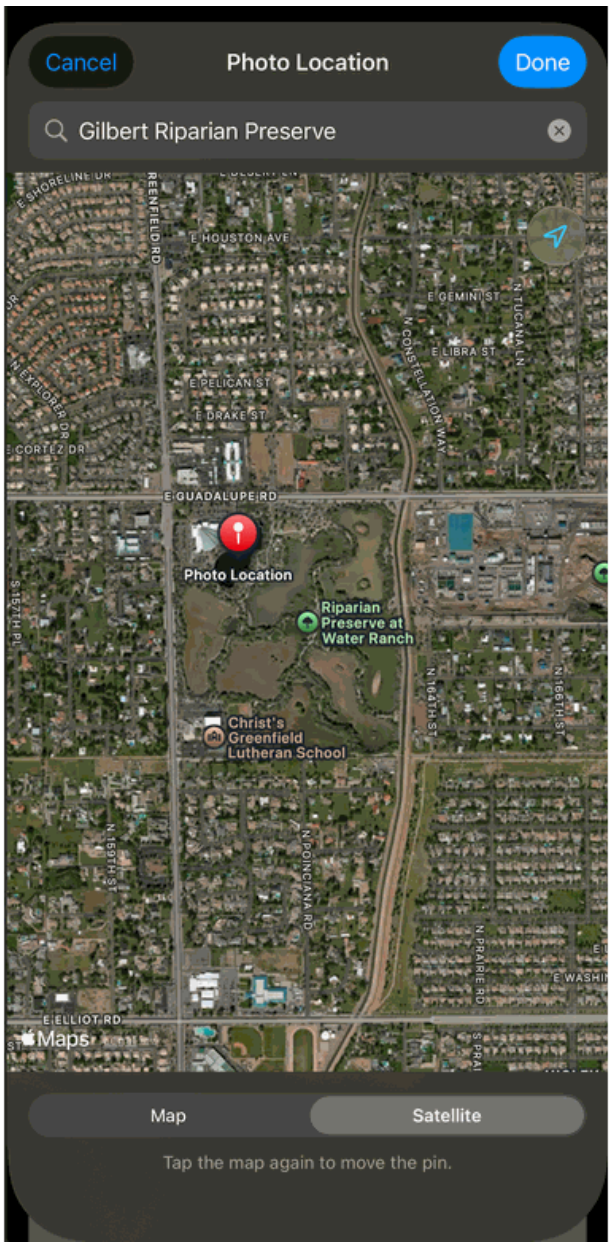


Photo Location screen with a pin in Satellite view (iPhone)

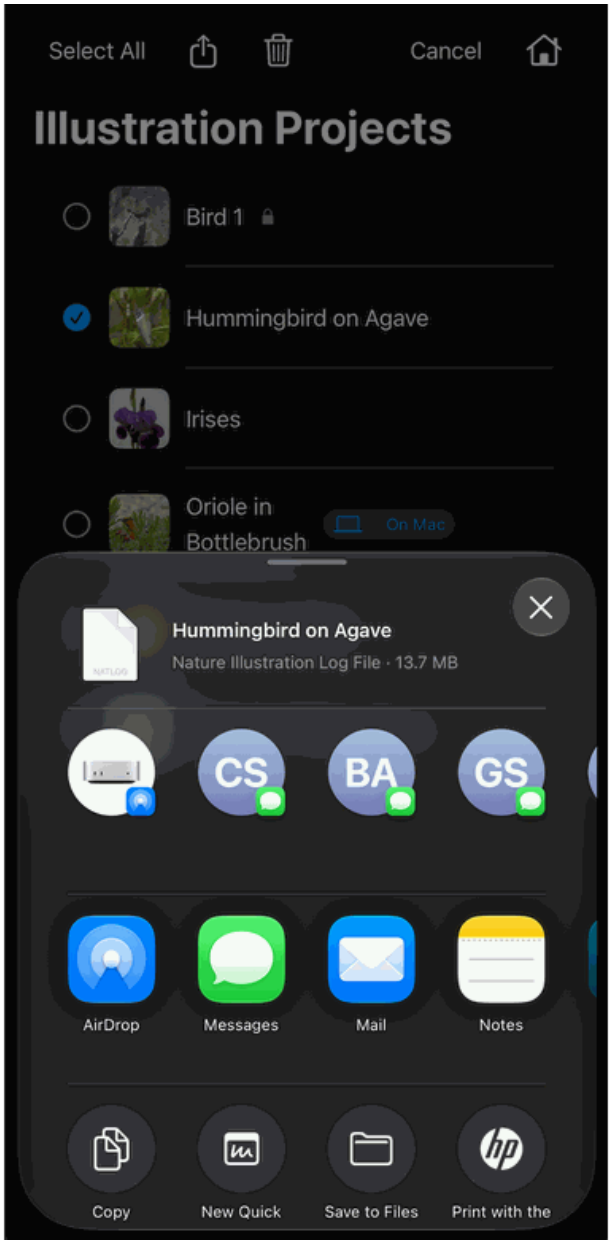
5. Moving files between your devices

Files travel as a single transfer file per subject, named for example **Great Blue Heron.natlog**, holding its photos, dates, notes and location. There's no automatic syncing: you send, and the other device imports.

Sending

1. In the File List, tap **Select**, check the files, and tap the **Share** icon. For a single file you can also long-press it (Mac: right-click).

2. Choose **Send to My Devices**. The files arrive editable.
3. Pick how to send in the share sheet: AirDrop, Messages, Mail, or **Save to Files** (iCloud Drive). The Mac has no Save to Files; choose **Save to a Folder…** instead, pick a folder such as iCloud Drive, and click **Copy**.



The share sheet: AirDrop, Messages, Mail and Save to Files (iPhone)

Receiving

- **Mac:** double-click the .natlog file in Finder, or use **File → Import Files…** (⌘I).
- **iPhone / iPad:** use **Settings → Import Files**. From the Files app, tapping a .natlog file shows a preview; tap **Share**, then the app's icon.

- When it's done, a summary shows how many files were imported or skipped.

Steps by method

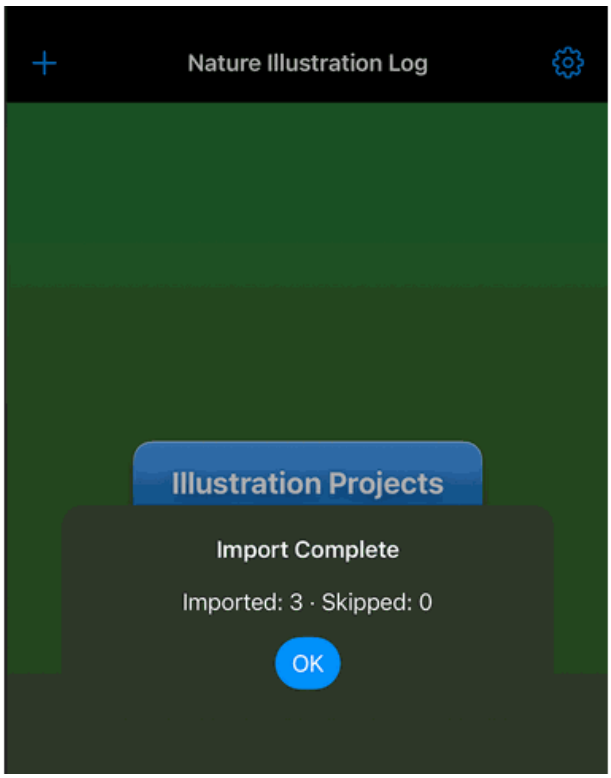
Sending

Method	Sending
AirDrop	Choose the other device in the share sheet
Mail	A new email opens with the file attached
Messages	Choose a conversation, file is attached
iCloud Drive	Save to Files → iCloud Drive (Mac: Save to a Folder… → iCloud Drive)

Receiving

Method	On iPhone / iPad
AirDrop	Choose to open it in the app
Mail	Tap the attachment's download icon or double-tap it, then open in the app
Messages	Press and hold the attachment for the download option, or tap it to save to Files; then Import Files
iCloud Drive	Settings → Import Files, pick from iCloud Drive

Method	On Mac
AirDrop	The file lands in Downloads, which opens; double-click it
Mail	Double-click the attachment and choose the app
Messages	Right-click the attachment, save to Downloads, then double-click or ⌘I
iCloud Drive	Open it from iCloud Drive in Finder, or ⌘I



The import summary (iPhone)

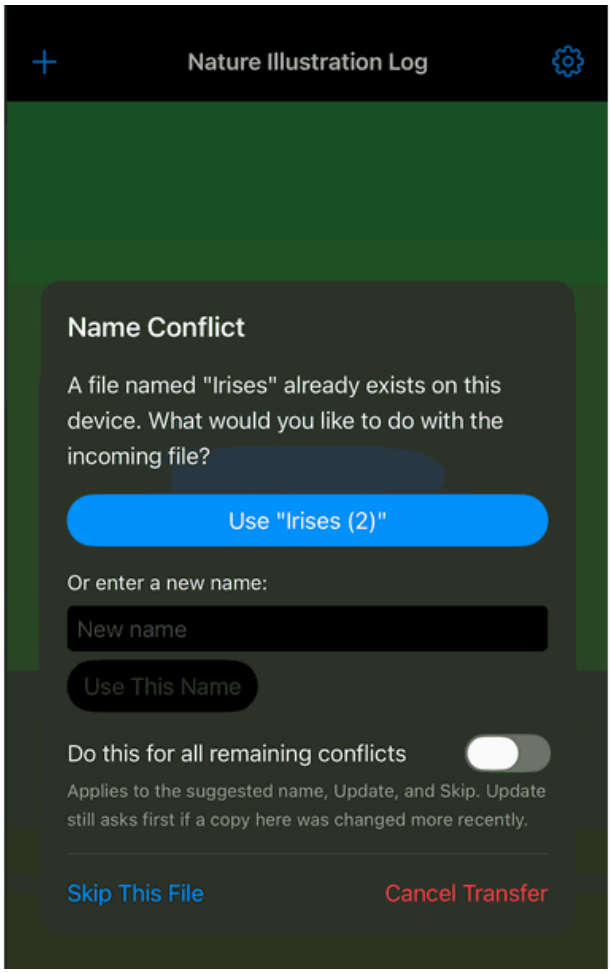
6. When a file name already exists

If an incoming file has the same name as one you already have, the app stops and asks; it never silently overwrites a file.

Choice	What happens
Use "Name (2)"	The incoming file is added under the suggested name
Enter a new name	Type your own; if that name is also taken, it asks again
Update This File	Shown only for the same file sent from one of your own devices. The incoming copy replaces yours; your previous version goes to Recently Replaced
Skip This File	This file isn't imported; other incoming continue
Cancel Transfer	Stops here; files already imported stay

If the copy on this device was changed more recently than the incoming one, **Update** asks **Update Anyway?** first.

When several files arrive, tick **Do this for all remaining conflicts** to reuse your answer. It covers the suggested name, Update and Skip. A standing Update still asks for any file you changed more recently here.

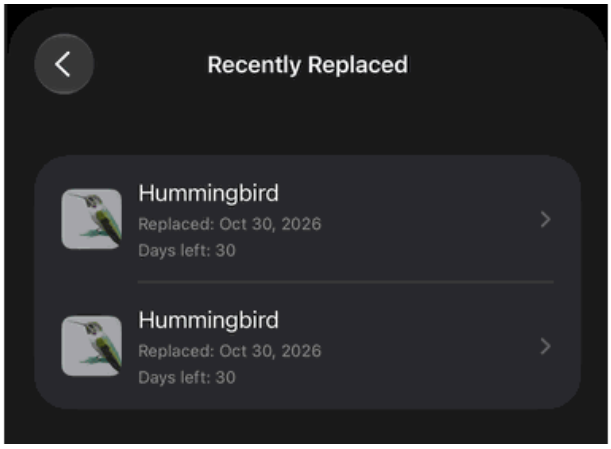


The Name Conflict card (iPhone)

Recently Replaced

Open **Settings → Recently Replaced**. Older versions are kept for **30 days**, then deleted automatically.

- Tap a version to view it, with **Restore** and **Delete Now** at the bottom.
- Or swipe right to **Restore**, left to **Delete Now**.
- If its name is now in use, Restore suggests a new name you can edit.



The Recently Replaced list (iPhone)

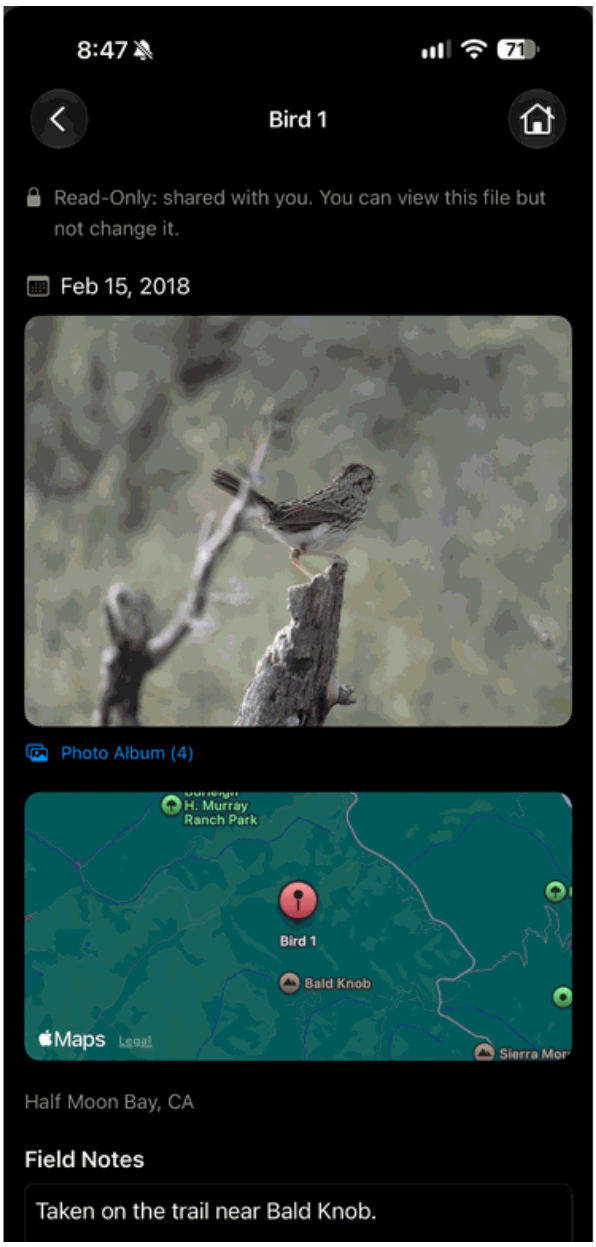
7. Sharing read-only copies

Use **Share Read-Only** to show your work to other people without letting them change it. The other person needs the app installed.

1. Select the files (or long-press / right-click one) and tap **Share**.
2. Choose **Share Read-Only**, then send as usual.

On their device the file shows a **lock** icon and a "Read-Only" line. They can view everything, including full-screen photos and the map, and they can delete their copy. They can't edit notes, dates, photos or the location, and they can't pass it on.

Read-only is enforced by the app; it isn't strong security. Share only what you're comfortable sharing.



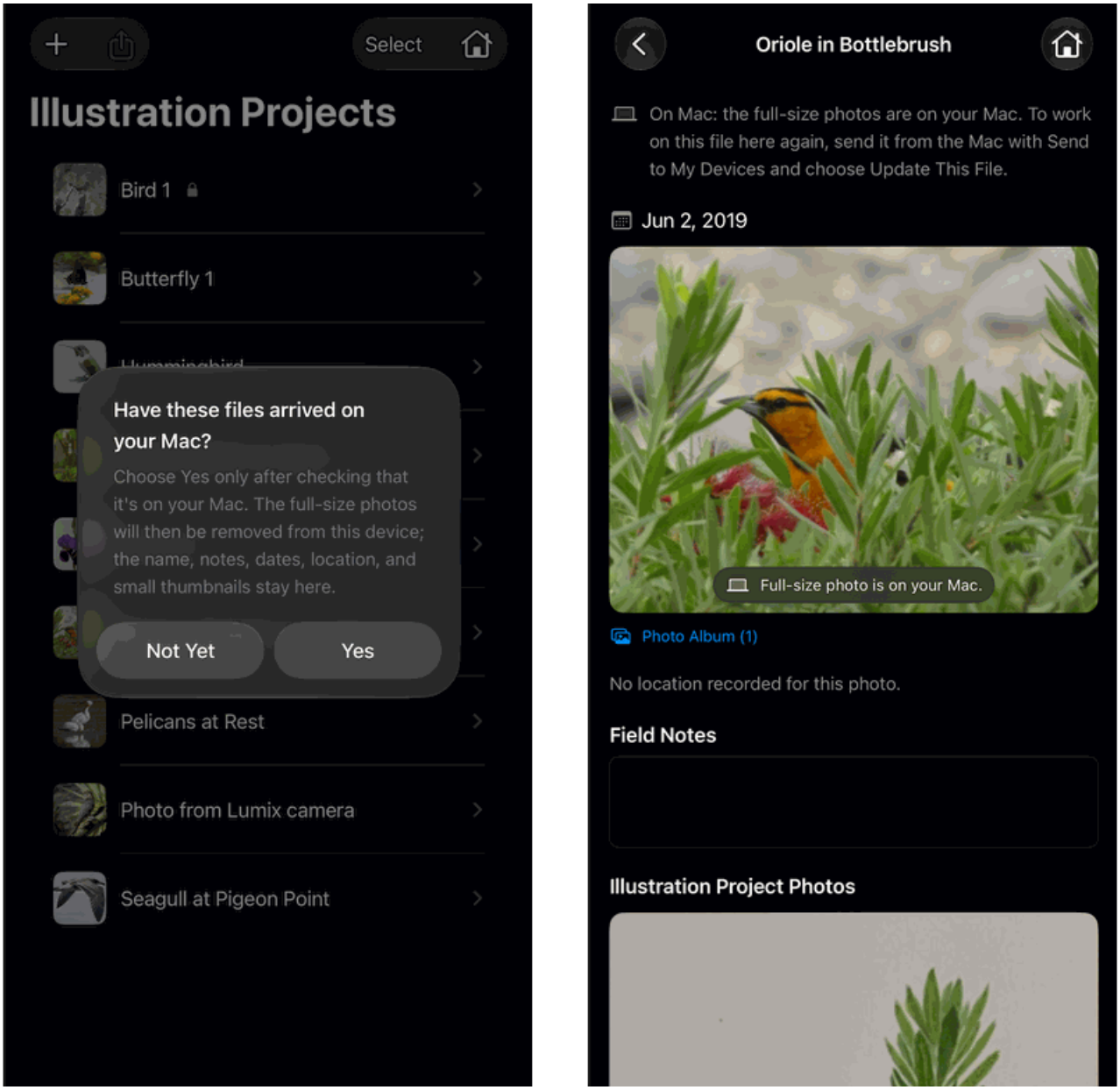
A read-only file with its lock and Read-Only line (iPhone)

8. Freeing space on iPhone and iPad

Send to Mac and Free Up Space moves a file's full-size photos to your Mac and keeps a lightweight copy on your iPhone or iPad. It's only on iPhone and iPad.

1. Select the files and tap **Share** (or long-press one file), then choose **Send to Mac and Free Up Space**.
2. Send them to your Mac, for example by AirDrop or iCloud Drive, and close the share window.

3. The app asks **Has this file arrived on your Mac?** (or "Have these files arrived on your Mac?" when you send several). Check on the Mac first.
    - **Yes**: the full-size photos are removed from this device.
    - **Not Yet**: nothing changes. Offload again later.



Left: the "Have these files arrived on your Mac?" question. Right: a file that is on the Mac, with the On Mac note and the full-size photo message (iPhone)

What stays on the iPhone

The file stays in your File List with an **On Mac** badge. It keeps its name, notes, dates, map and small thumbnails, read-only. Photos show **Full-size photo is on your Mac.** Only small copies stay on the iPhone, so photos look blurry if you zoom in.

Bringing a file back

On the Mac, send the file with **Send to My Devices**. On the iPhone, choose **Update This File**. The full file replaces the lightweight copy, and the summary says **Full files brought back from the Mac**.

Deleting a lightweight copy removes it from this device only; the full file on your Mac is not affected.

9. Using the Mac version

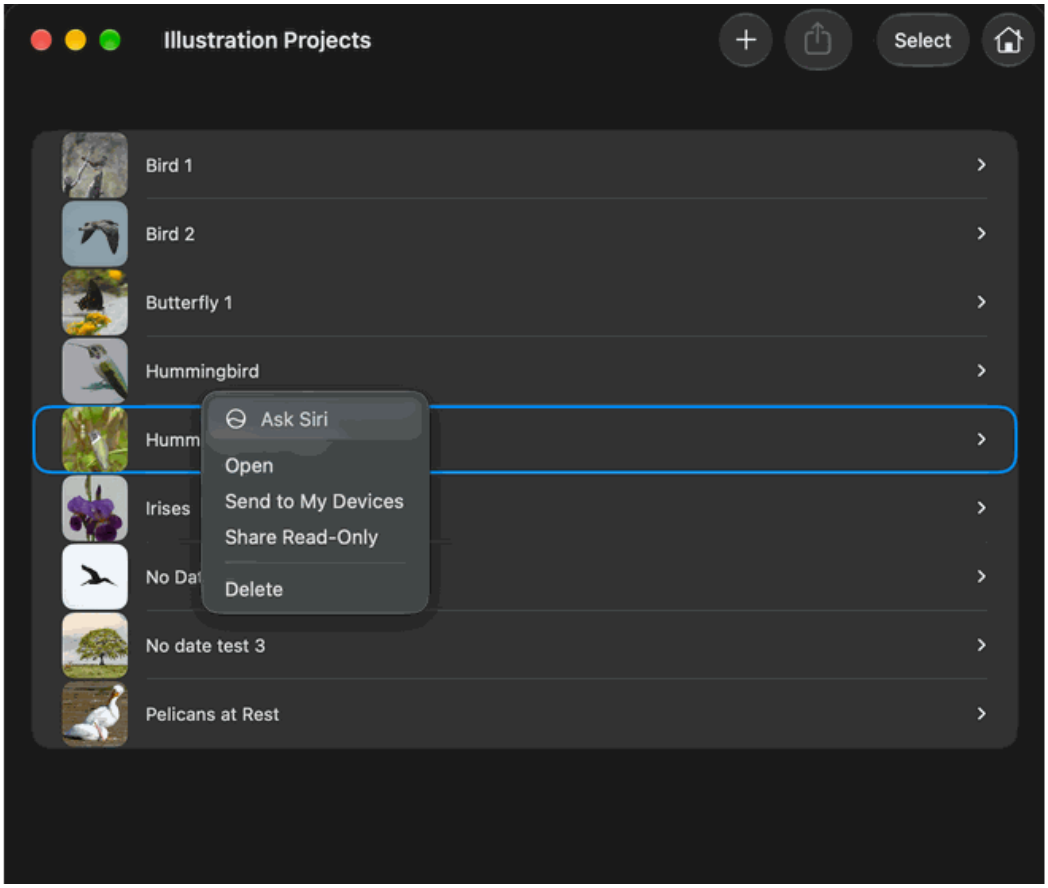
The Mac version has the same screens and works the same way as on iPhone, with a few Mac additions. It needs macOS 27 or later.

Action	On the Mac
New file	File → New File, or ⌘N
Import files	File → Import Files…, ⌘I, or double-click a .natlog file in Finder
Options for a file or photo	Right-click it (Open, Send, Share Read-Only, Delete; Set as First, Delete)
Delete checked items in Select mode	The trash icon or the Delete key
Swipe actions	Two-finger swipe on the trackpad
Zoom a photo	Pinch on the trackpad, or double-click
Bigger photos and maps	Drag the window's edges, or the green button for full screen

Differences from the iPhone:

- The top-bar buttons all sit at the top right, because the window controls take the left.
- The app's name is in the window title bar, not on the Home screen.

- **Send to Mac and Free Up Space** isn't offered; the Mac keeps full files.



The Mac File List with a right-click menu open (Mac)

10. Troubleshooting

Problem	What to do
"Photo Access Not Available"	Tap **Open Settings** and turn on full Photos access for the app (Mac: System Settings → Privacy & Security → Photos). Or tap **Continue Anyway** and enter dates by hand
"Camera Access Is Off"	Tap Open Settings and turn on Camera for the app. Photos Library and Files still work meanwhile
Take Photo isn't in the menu	It's only on iPhone and iPad. On the Mac, use Photos Library or Files

Problem	What to do
The map doesn't show where I am	Allow Location access for the app in Settings (Mac: Privacy & Security → Location Services)
The location arrow says it couldn't find your location	Indoors or under heavy cover the device may not get a fix in time. Try again in the open, or tap the map to drop the pin
Place search finds nothing	Check your internet connection; you can still pin the spot by hand
I can't see my other device in AirDrop	Set AirDrop to Everyone for 10 minutes, turn Wi-Fi and Bluetooth on, keep the iPhone unlocked and close to the Mac, and on the Mac make sure the firewall isn't blocking incoming connections. Restarting both devices often helps. Or use iCloud Drive instead.
Tapping a .natlog file in the Files app only shows a preview	Tap **Share**, then the app's icon, or use Settings → Import Files
"Not Enough Space"	Free up space on the device, or offload files to your Mac
"File Exists" when saving	Choose a name no other file uses
A file shows "Couldn't read" after import	The transfer file was damaged or incomplete; send it again
I replaced a file by mistake	Restore it from Settings → Recently Replaced within 30 days
A file says "On Mac" and can't be edited	Send it back from the Mac with Send to My Devices and choose Update This File